

Iran's Revolutionary Decade, Under Exam Conditions

Lesson 27 — Essay practice: Iran, 1953–1981

What you will know and be able to do

1

Write a complete, timed essay drawing on everything from Lessons 22–26

2

Apply command-term discipline, structure, historiography, and evaluation together

3

Self-assess against the criteria built since Lesson 1

4

Close Block B4 ready to examine Gulf oil politics and the region's monarchies

From a toppled prime minister to a new theocracy

Five lessons have traced an unbroken chain: a 1953 coup, reforms that alienated the clergy, a revolution built on accumulated grievance, and a new state defined against its former ally. Today tests whether you can weigh this entire arc together.

A full argument-evaluation essay

“The 1953 coup made the 1979 revolution possible, but it did not make an Islamic Republic, specifically, inevitable.” To what extent do you agree?

A representative Paper 3 style question drawing on Lessons 22–26.

PRACTICE • 40 MIN

Write your complete essay now

Write a full essay in response to today's question, under real time pressure, without looking back at earlier lesson slides until you finish.

- Plan your position and structure before writing a single sentence
- Use specific evidence from at least three of Lessons 22–26
- Integrate at least one genuine historiographical reference
- Reach a real, specific judgement in your conclusion

Checking your own essay

Did you separate “caused a revolution” from “caused specifically this kind of revolution”? Did you use Khomeini's own doctrine, developed years before 1979, as evidence for or against inevitability? Did your conclusion reach a genuine, specific judgement about causation, not just a chronology?

What a strong final judgement sounds like

“1953 discredited secular, democratic politics in Iran and left the clergy as one of the few institutions never fully co-opted by the Shah, making some form of religiously inflected opposition likely. That the specific outcome was Khomeini's velayat-e faqih, rather than a more pluralist alternative, owed at least as much to his own political skill in 1979 as to anything set in motion in 1953.”

What Block B5 covers next

While Iran turned inward and against the West, the Gulf monarchies pursued an entirely different relationship with oil, foreign powers, and their own populations. Block B5 covers that contrast in full.

Block B4 recap

Operation Ajax

The 1953 coup restoring the Shah to full power.

Velayat-e faqih

Khomeini's doctrine of clerical governance, realised in the 1979 constitution.

White Revolution

The Shah's 1963 reforms, alienating clergy and traditional elites.

444-day hostage crisis

The event that defined the new republic's relationship with the West.

What we now understand about this era

From a democratically elected prime minister toppled by foreign intervention, through decades of top-down reform and repression, to a revolution that installed clerical rule and defined itself against the United States — a single, connected arc in which each stage's grievances shaped the next.

Lesson 28 — Gulf monarchies and the oil economy

Next lesson starts Block B5: how Saudi Arabia and the smaller Gulf states used oil wealth to build an entirely different kind of political stability.